

The Shingba Rhododendron Sanctuary near Lachung

Lachung

Quite close to the Tibetan (India-China) border, about 125 km away from Gangtok and 2,900 metres above sea level, this quaint hill town sits at the confluence of the Lachung and Lachen rivers, which finally feed into the Teesta. With Lachung as your base, you can explore the glorious Yumthang Valley (just 25 kms away), filled with grazing wild yak and outlined with gleaming glaciers, or visit the Shingba Rhododendron Sanctuary, awash with more than 40 varieties of colourful blossoms between April and July. If you're lucky, you might even spot the extremely rare snow leopard or the most adorable-looking Himalayan red panda. A small detour will bring you to hot springs or even Zero Point, which is the last civilian outpost at 15,300 feet before the border. Slightly even more off-the-beaten track is the special territory of Dzongu, home to the Lepchas. A walk through the reserve will give you insights into the lifestyle and culture of these indigenous people. Meeting them is akin to feeling the pulse of the real residents of Sikkim.



Guru Padmasambhava's statue on Samdruptse Hill

Namchi

About 73 km from Gangtok, it is becoming a popular spot, thanks to a huge statue of Guru Padmasambhava on Samdruptse Hill. In the south at Solophok, you'll also get to see replicas of the Char Dham, some of the most significant religious places for Hindus. The well-kept spaces and beautifully painted exteriors exude joy and peace.